

Checklist:

Leading a Small Team

Build trust

- ☐ Create an environment where people can tell me what they really think
- ☐ Make it safe for reports to bring me their biggest challenges
- ☐ Give and receive critical feedback without taking it personally
- ☐ Ask myself honestly whether my team would choose to work for me again
- ☐ Let 1:1s include some awkward but meaningful conversations

Be human

- ☐ Show care and respect for each report as a person, not just as a performer
- ☐ Invest regular time in each report
- ☐ Hold at least one weekly 1:1 with each direct report
- ☐ Focus 1:1s on the report's priorities, growth, and obstacles, not just status updates
- ☐ Ask more questions instead of jumping straight to advice

Run useful 1:1s

- ☐ Discuss top priorities and most important outcomes
- ☐ Calibrate what "great" looks like
- ☐ Share feedback in both directions
- ☐ Check how the person is feeling overall
- ☐ Ask: "What's top of mind for you right now?"
- ☐ Ask: "How can I help?"
- ☐ Ask: "What was most useful about today's conversation?"

Be clear about performance

- ☐ Make sure each report knows what I expect
- ☐ Be transparent about how I think they're doing
- ☐ Address concerns early instead of letting ambiguity linger
- ☐ Diagnose whether a problem is about skill, motivation, or fit

Model vulnerability and accountability

- ☐ Admit my own mistakes quickly
- ☐ Apologize clearly when I get something wrong
- ☐ Share growth areas and uncertainties honestly
- ☐ Lead with empathy during hard moments

Help people play to their strengths

- ☐ Notice and name each person's strengths specifically
- ☐ Create opportunities for people to use their strengths more
- ☐ Spend disproportionate time helping strong people get even better
- ☐ Avoid letting low performance consume all my attention

Protect team culture

- ☐ Refuse to tolerate brilliant jerks or toxic behavior
- ☐ Hold a high bar for collaboration and kindness
- ☐ Remember that one divider can reduce the whole team's effectiveness

Be honest about fit

- ☐ Recognize when someone's values, aspirations, or working style don't fit the role
- ☐ Stop trying to "make it work" forever when evidence says otherwise
- ☐ Explore better-fit roles when possible
- ☐ Move people out of roles quickly and respectfully when needed

Keep the big picture in mind

- ☐ Remember that management is about getting better outcomes through people
- ☐ Prioritize people first, then process
- ☐ Build a small-team culture of honesty, debate, and collaboration
- ☐ Leave conversations with clear next steps